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Mahatma Gandhi Institute of
Education for Peace and
Sustainable Development

Skill 2: Ethical Mindfulness

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define Ethical Mindfulness
- Identify the three components of ethical mindfulness.
- Describe the significance of attention stability.
- Demonstrate how to practice mindfulness in daily activities
- Analyze scenarios to determine how ethical mindfulness can influence outcomes

Definition of Ethical Mindfulness

Think of a time when you said something in a fit of anger, something you didn't mean. What happened after that incident? Did you feel regret and embarrassment? Many of us have experienced this, and it often leaves us wishing we had acted differently. Skill two of this course addresses exactly that: how to act in accordance with our values even in challenging situations.

Ethical Mindfulness is defined as the ability to maintain one's identity and core values while speaking and acting accordingly. It involves living in a way that consistently reflects our principles, even under stress or pressure.

To illustrate this concept, consider these scenarios:

Scenario 1: Imagine you receive unexpected criticism from your boss. Your initial reaction might be to defend yourself or lash out/show anger. However, with ethical mindfulness, you can take a moment to breathe, reflect on your values, and respond calmly and constructively/positively

Scenario 2: Picture a situation where a friend says something hurtful. Instead of reacting impulsively, you pause and remember your value of maintaining strong relationships. This helps you respond with understanding and find a solution rather than starting a fight/conflict

Scenario 3: Think about being under immense pressure before an exam. Ethical mindfulness can guide you to manage your stress in a way that aligns with your value of integrity, so you avoid cheating or taking unethical shortcuts.

Ethical Mindfulness comprises 3 components - Heedfulness, Mindfulness and Awareness.

Components of Ethical Mindfulness

Heedfulness

We may have noticed that sometimes we pay less attention to the way we speak or act, but after the event, we realize that our speech and actions may have caused harm to ourselves or others. The first step in the process of ethical mindfulness is to be aware of how our thoughts and actions can be harmful to ourselves and others.

An ancient Indian metaphor used to teach this level of heedfulness is that of a person who was ordered to carry a bowl filled right to the brim with hot sesame oil, while a guard holding a drawn sword walked behind him. If the person spilled even a drop of sesame oil, the guard was instructed to chop his head off. Clearly, in such a situation, we would be extremely careful. This metaphor explains what heedfulness is: a sense of care and restraint with regard to things we recognize as dangerous. Often, however, we lack heedfulness and only realize our mistakes in hindsight./ An old Indian metaphor teaches heedfulness with a story: a person had to carry a bowl of hot sesame oil while a guard with a sword followed him. If he spilled even a drop, the guard would be ordered to chop off his head. This shows heedfulness as being very careful about dangerous things. Often, we don't practice heedfulness and only see our mistakes later.

Reflect on this:

You're scrolling through social media and see a post that makes you angry. You feel like leaving a harsh comment.

How will you use heedfulness in this situation?

Mindfulness

There are several popular definitions of mindfulness. In SEEK, we define mindfulness focusing your attention on something intentionally to remember it better. Essentially, it means being aware of the values and behaviors we want to adopt or avoid.

For example, through heedfulness we might realize we often say upsetting or critical things to others. Despite heedfulness, if we're not mindful of our value to avoid harming others with our words, we might keep doing it. By cultivating mindfulness, we remember our values during stressful times and change our behavior accordingly.

Reflect on this:

You desperately want to spend your savings on a new gadget you don't really need. How will you apply mindfulness to this situation?

Awareness

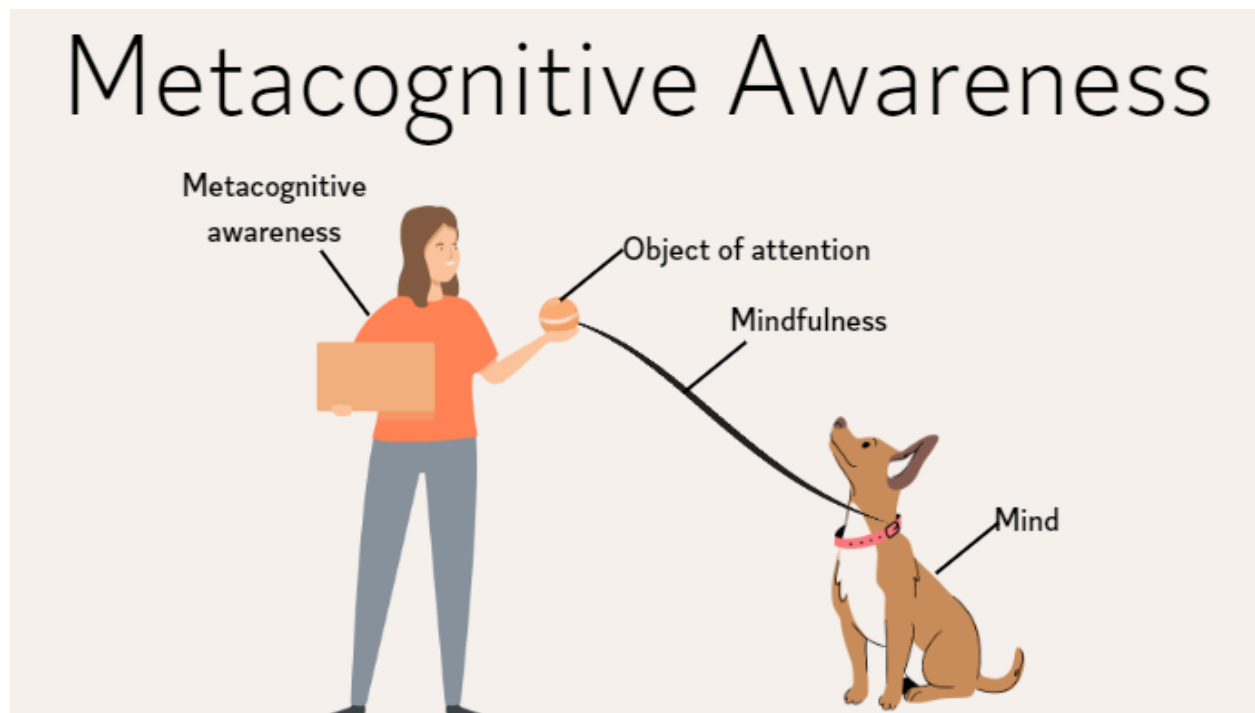
Awareness is being conscious of our thoughts and actions in the present moment. If we are not aware of how we speak or behave in the present moment, we can cause harm to ourselves and others even if we are heedful and mindful.

For example, if we realize we can harm others with our words (heedfulness) and want to avoid doing so (mindfulness), we might still cause harm if we're not aware of what we're saying in the moment. The same goes for our actions. Even with heedfulness and mindfulness, we can still harm ourselves and others if we're not aware of what we're doing right now.

Reflect on this:

You are participating in a team activity and notice that you are suddenly becoming overly aggressive and competitive. How will you apply awareness here?

Attention Stability and Metacognitive Awareness



The significance of attention stability can be understood through the concept of metacognitive awareness, which involves being aware of where our attention is at any given moment. Imagine your mind is like a playful puppy. Just like a puppy that runs around, our mind tends to wander, jumping from one thought to another. This can create problems, especially when we need to focus on studying or working, and our mind is instead worrying about the future or thinking about the past.

In this metaphor, the puppy is on a leash, and its owner holds a ball in her hand. The ball represents our object of attention—what we are trying to focus on. The leash is like our capacity for mindfulness or attention, helping us keep our focus on the ball. When the puppy begins to roam or move away from the owner, she recognizes this and calls the puppy back, reminding it to stay focused on the ball.

Similarly, when our mind starts to wander, we need metacognition (also called introspective awareness) to recognize when we have drifted away from our focus. By being aware of our wandering mind, we can gently bring our attention back to the task at hand. This practice helps us maintain attention stability, ensuring that we stay focused and aligned with our goals and values.

Ethical mindfulness combines heedfulness, mindfulness, and awareness to help us act in ways that are consistent with our values, even when our mind tries to wander. By practicing attention stability, we can improve our ability to stay focused, make better decisions, and avoid actions that might harm ourselves or others.